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As Professor Kaviraj, who teaches political science at Lucknow University, points out, "Akhilesh should know by now that just by taking a few non-Yadav OBC leaders, you cannot expect the whole caste to vote for you. *Neta ka aana unki jaati ka saath aa jana nahin hota* (A politician's joining is no guarantee of his caste accompanying him)." Akhilesh also faltered by not bringing up issues concerning the Dalits—be it atrocities or reservations—in his speeches. The academic, though, does concede that there are lessons for Akhilesh in this defeat, and should he work on them, the future for him and his party may prove far brighter. ■

– Prashant Srivastava

situation in the state had undergone a sea change under the Yogi dispensation. The CM wore the 'Bulldozer Baba' epithet proudly, even as toy bulldozers flooded the market. "For the first time in an assembly election," says Prof. S.K. Dwivedi, the former HoD of the political science department at the Lucknow University, "a ruling party made strict action against criminals and improvement in the law and order situation election issues. Earlier, law and order in the state used to be the reason for the defeat of the ruling party."

Yogi had deployed Additional Director General of Police (ADG)-level officers in each zone of the state and Inspector General of Police (IG)-level officers in the range soon after he became chief minister in 2017. The 1987-batch IAS officer Avanish Awasthi was given the responsibility of bettering the law and order situation in the state; he was made principal secretary in the home department in 2019 and then the additional chief secretary in the same department. Listing the achievements during Yogi's tenure, Awasthi says, "The UP Police took swift action against 35 mafia and eight notorious criminals between January 2020 and December 2021, either confiscating their property worth Rs 1,128 crore or demolishing their illegal constructions." Awasthi also elaborates the 'crackdown' on criminals in the Yogi regime. "A list of notorious criminals was prepared in every district and a special police team formed to nab them," he says. "In the past five years, 137 criminals have been killed in encounters and 2,782 injured."

While such statistics these had led to accusations of encounter killings or the targeting of Muslims, it did not seem to matter to the electorate while casting their vote. Nor did other controversial aspects of Yogi's rule, it seems, be it the anti-Romeo squads, the anti-conversion law, the rape and killing in Hathras or the Lakhimpur Kheri incident. Caste and religion, Yogi Adityanath was at pains to point out in his victory speech, had ceased to be factors in elections. Yet, the 51 per cent non-Jatav vote that probably went to BJP, as per the exit poll, certainly made a difference to the tally. (Dalits form 22 per cent of the state's population. The Jatav vote remains firmly with Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party.) A rise of 20 percentage points from 2017, the fresh accrual of the non-Jatav vote would have resulted in a growth of almost 2 per cent in the overall vote share. Similarly with the non-Yadav OBC (Other Backward Class) vote. The BJP either held on to their support or increased it by as much as 5 per cent in some parts of the state.

Finally, the combined equity of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Yogi Adityanath seems to have convinced the voters to repose their faith in the BJP. Several candidates who faced anti-incumbency scraped through thanks to the power of the two. Home minister Amit Shah worked the magic elsewhere. Days ahead of the election, he held a door-to-door campaign in the politically crucial western UP. He also met several Jat leaders during the polls, to soothe any leftover ruffled sentiment over the farm laws.

The party's formidable electoral machinery did the rest. The central leadership descended on UP, holding *jan vishwas yatras*, addressing public meetings and attending *nukkad sabhas*. With the Election Commission restricting physical rallies in the wake of the Omicron wave, the party ensured its virtual meetings could accommodate 50,000 people at a time.

Mostly, though, Election 2022 was a Yogi Adityanath show. Having now successfully demonstrated his electoral chops, there are whispers of him one day succeeding Narendra Modi to the country's top post. The win in UP has certainly pushed him a few rungs up in the top leadership ladder of the party. ■